

Dylan Fino UX Researcher

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I operate as the **translation layer between customer reality and business strategy**. I am customer-obsessed, focused on understanding how customers think and feel, what makes them tick and what ticks them off, and how those realities should shape product and business decisions. I pull from as many relevant data sources as necessary and speak directly with customers and stakeholders across functions to maximize understanding and clarity. I specialize in distilling these signals into clear, decision-grade guidance, applying research that is as fast and as rigorous as the moment demands, and turning customer insight into aligned strategy, roadmap direction, and measurable impact. I **identify the single highest-impact problem and force my time and attention there**. The people that are working hardest on the most important problems likely don't have time to fill out a research intake form.

Research Showcase 1: Do Off-Amazon Sellers Want Faster Shipping Speeds?

Executive Summary

Amazon leadership faced a high-stakes strategic decision: whether to invest heavily in same-day and sub-same-day shipping capabilities for off-Amazon fulfillment (Multi-Channel Fulfillment, MCF). Despite internal pressure to mirror Amazon.com's speed leadership, early signals suggested limited merchant demand. I led a multi-method research program that resolved a long-standing internal debate, redirected a \$1B+ roadmap, and reframed how leadership evaluated "speed" as a value proposition for SMB DTC merchants.

Outcome: Prevented misaligned investment in faster shipping speeds for 2026 planning and redirected the roadmap toward configurable, merchant-centric fulfillment capabilities now embedded in our 2026-2028+ roadmap.

The Business Question

If we build it, will they use it...and will it pay off?

In late 2025, the L8 Product Director for MCF requested research to inform 2026–2028 planning:

Should Amazon invest in developing same-day or sub-same-day shipping for off-Amazon sellers?

Context:

- MCF launched **3-Business-Day Standard (3BDS)** in September 2024.
- A prior pilot (Oct 2023) showed promise, generating **2.7M incremental unit commitments**.
- However, the broad rollout produced **mixed adoption and weak sustained demand**.
- Over **7,000 merchant feedback signals** showed no organic demand for faster-than-3-day speeds.

Product leadership believed speed parity with Amazon.com was strategically necessary. IC product leaders believed adoption would be minimal. Research was asked to resolve the conflict with evidence.

My Role

Senior UXR, end-to-end research owner

I was personally asked to:

- Resolve a director- and principal-level disagreement blocking roadmap decisions
- Translate ambiguous customer sentiment into an unambiguous strategic recommendation
- Provide leadership-ready guidance under tight planning timelines

I owned:

- Problem framing and success criteria
 - Research design and triangulation strategy
 - Qualitative fieldwork
 - Synthesis, storytelling, and executive readouts
 - Cross-org alignment (Product, Ops, AFN, SCOT, NATS)
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Research Approach

Triangulation over volume. Rigor over instinct.

I combined existing internal signals with a focused qualitative deep dive to understand not just *what* merchants were doing, but *why*.

Existing Data Analyzed

- **7,000+ merchant feedback echoes** (AI-assisted thematic analysis)
- **3BDS pilot results** (Oct 2023)
- **3BDS broad rollout performance** (Sept 2024)

These sources answered *what happened*, but not *why*.

Primary Research

- **11 in-depth interviews** (90 minutes each)
- SMB DTC merchants (\$1M–\$50M ARR)
- ~1,000+ MCF orders/month
- Roles: Heads of Ops, Logistics, Supply Chain
- 5–15 years fulfillment experience across B2C, B2B, and marketplaces

Topics Explored

- Decision-making process for existing shipping speeds
- Perceived customer expectations by shipping speed
- Willingness to pay for 1-day / same-day delivery
- Inventory placement and operational complexity
- Tradeoffs vs. smaller, more flexible 3PLs

The goal here was **decision-grade clarity**, not discovery theater.

Key Insights

Five findings consistently emerged across data sources and directly challenged internal assumptions:

1. Demand for Faster-Than-3-Day Shipping Was Limited

Merchants reported **minimal customer pressure** for same-day or sub-same-day delivery. Existing 2–3 day expedited options already met expectations.

Speed beyond 3 days was “nice to have,” not table stakes.

2. Cost Was the Primary Constraint

Merchants could not justify incremental fulfillment costs, especially amid macroeconomic pressure, even when they found the idea of faster shipping appealing in theory.

3. ROI Was Unproven

Merchants lacked credible evidence that faster shipping:

- Increased conversion
- Reduced cart abandonment
- Improved retention

Without ROI clarity, speed investments stalled.

4. Flexibility Mattered More Than Speed

Merchants consistently prioritized:

- Custom packaging and branding
- Bundling and kitting
- Order edits and routing flexibility

MCF was perceived as **fast but rigid** relative to smaller 3PLs.

5. Competitive Pressure Was Decreasing, Not Increasing

China-based marketplaces (Temu, Shein) were normalizing slower delivery windows, reducing urgency to compete purely on speed.

Impact on Strategy

This research changed the roadmap.

Rather than accelerating faster standard shipping, leadership pivoted toward **configurable fulfillment** as the core differentiator.

Strategic Shift

From:

“Faster is always better.”

To:

“Merchants want control across speed, cost, and operations.”

Resulting Roadmap Framework

Crawl (2025–2026)

- MCF-enabled inventory placement supporting multiple speed tiers

Walk (2026–2027)

- Configurable fulfillment models balancing speed, cost, and complexity

Run (2027+)

- Gradual acceleration of shopper expectations once value is proven

Organizational Impact

- Informed **July 2025 MCF Speed Strategy**
- Embedded into **2026 OP1 planning**
- Influenced roadmap decisions through **2028+**
- Created alignment across MCF, AFN, SCOT, and NATS

Most importantly, the research **prevented costly misinvestment** in capabilities merchants were not ready to adopt.

Why did I choose this project?

This project exemplifies how I operate as a UXR:

- I resolve ambiguous, high-stakes debates with evidence
 - I translate customer sentiment into roadmap-level decisions
 - I am comfortable recommending *against* prevailing internal narratives (even those backed by multi-trillion dollar entities yikes!)
 - I optimize for business impact, not research artifacts
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Research Showcase 2: Why Were Buy with Prime Onboarding Rates So Low?

Executive Summary

Ahead of a high-visibility Shopify app launch, Buy with Prime faced persistently low merchant onboarding completion, despite strong interest in the value proposition. With no prior merchant feedback on the onboarding flow and launch timelines locked, I initiated and led a rapid, decision-oriented research effort that revealed a critical SKU-matching failure blocking adoption. The findings prompted immediate leadership action, unlocked \$1M+ in investment, and resulted in a redesigned “fuzzy” SKU-matching system that materially improved onboarding efficiency and long-term merchant growth.

Outcome: Reduced onboarding time by 35%, increased SKU parity from 45% to 56.2% by EOY, and delivered cross-product benefits to both Buy with Prime and MCF.

The Business Problem

Buy with Prime enables merchants to offer Prime benefits on their own DTC sites, but only if they successfully onboard and map SKUs between Shopify and Amazon systems.

Leading into launch:

- Onboarding was known internally to be “difficult,” but not well understood
- No merchant research had been conducted on the actual flows
- Shopify app launch was ~3 months away
- Failure risk was high, but invisible

The question was no longer “*Is onboarding hard?*” but:

Where exactly is it breaking, and what do we do about it now?

My Role

Senior UXR, self-initiated, end-to-end owner

- Proactively identified onboarding as a launch-critical risk
- Designed and executed rapid qualitative research under tight timelines
- Recruited merchants via Sales partnerships
- Ran live, streamed usability sessions with Product, Design, and GTM stakeholders

- Facilitated leadership listening sessions to drive accountability and action
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Research Approach

Fast, high-signal qualitative testing optimized for action

- Sales-recruited Buy with Prime merchants
- Live usability testing of real onboarding flows
- Sessions streamed directly to stakeholders
- Immediate synthesis focused on failure points, not polish

This approach surfaced issues traditional metrics had masked.

Key Insight

The primary blocker was **SKU matching**.

Merchants consistently failed during SKU setup due to:

- Rigid, exact-match requirements
- Confusing system expectations between Shopify SKUs and Amazon SKUs
- No recovery path when matches failed

After watching a clips from the sessions, our org VP said:

“Can’t we just throw \$1 million at this to fix it?”

Impact

The research directly led to:

- Executive approval for a \$1M+ investment
 - Design and launch of “fuzzy” SKU matching within one month
 - Measurable improvements documented in the Buy with Prime Quarterly Performance Report:
 - **+2,500 bps increase** in FBA unit-weighted SKU parity by EOY
 - **35% reduction** in merchant onboarding time
 - Benefits extended to both Buy with Prime *and* unified MCF onboarding
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Why This Project

This project reflects how I operate as a senior researcher:

- I surface invisible risks before they become launch failures
- I design research for speed, clarity, and executive decision-making
- I turn qualitative evidence into concrete investment and roadmap change
- I optimize for outcomes, not artifacts

End of Portfolio Doc

MaxDiff for Prime Branding & Feature Guardrails for Off-Amazon Experiences

Established the evidence base that directly informed the Prime feature-set and branding guidelines for off-Amazon programs. Produced research that clarified customer expectations of Prime benefits, seller value trade-offs, and brand risk boundaries. These guidelines became the standard reference for product teams building new Prime-eligible features and for sales teams negotiating offerings with external partners, ensuring consistency, protecting brand equity, and accelerating go-to-market decisions. Standard referenced for multi-year multi-million dollar agreements with several billion dollar partner companies.